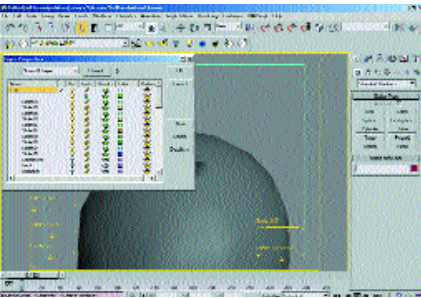


Reactor allows you to add dynamic properties to the object

Reactor, which was sold as a separate program, is now a part of 3ds max 5. A dynamic system now lets you assign physical properties to an object. With so many enhancements, generating animations in this version is less tedious.

Scene management

The inclusion of Layers in this version is an excellent feature that makes it easier to manage the information in your scenes. Layers are like transparencies on which you organise and group different kinds of



Inclusion of Layers has simplified work flow

scene information. The objects you create can have common properties including colour, visibility, renderability and display. An object can inherit these properties from the layer on which you create it.

You can place multiple objects and scene elements on layers with an easy-to-use manager that enables quick revealing/hiding/freezing of scene data. This lets artists keep track of scene data while building 3D elements with Compositing Layers in mind. This feature also intelligently groups scene data, provides commonly used Layering commands and offers the flexibility to render only select objects from a scene, thus reducing the rendering time and the animation file size.

Texturing

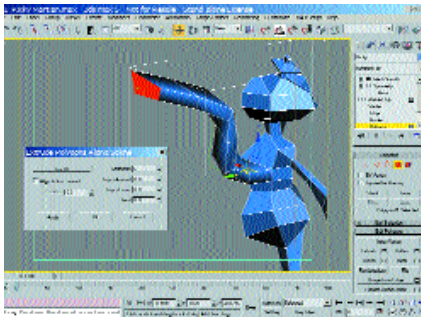
Any object that is assigned a 2D material must have the requisite mapping coordinates that specify how the material is

‘mapped’ onto the object and whether it is projected as a ‘decal’, or is tiled or mirrored. Mapping coordinates are also known as UV or UVW coordinates. These letters refer to coordinates in the object’s own space, as opposed to the XYZ coordinates that describe the scene as a whole. A re-designed UV unwrap interface puts common tools and tasks at the artist’s fingertips. Three Unwrapping types (Flatten, Normal and Unfold) and a slew of selection and navigation tools are now available to make texturing more predictable and easier to manage. A major benefit of this feature is that automatic texture layouts can be created to save time painting textures.

Modelling

Version 5 of 3ds max provides extended polygonal modelling tools, with greater degrees of interactivity and better ways of selecting and managing polygons and selection sets. Building, connecting and extending polygon meshes and their sub-object components is a lot easier with these enhancements. The Quick Slice tool allows you to slice objects which previously had to be done manually and the introduction of the Inset function (which was earlier available as a third-party script) allows you to add another polygon over the object for better results when the Mesh Smoother modifier is applied.

A new Modifier called Symmetry now allows you to automatically merge a mirrored object to the original object. The Extrude Along Spline feature permits an extrusion of a selection along the vertices of a spline, due to which an extrude is no longer always perpendicular to the face of a path, as was the case previously.



Polygonal tools allow extruding polygons along a path

Lighting and rendering

The most painful process an animator faces is the rendering time. The process takes so long that most animators prefer to start the rendering process when they leave office, allowing it to render overnight. In version 5, we see a new feature called Render to Texture, also known as ‘texture baking’. This is the process of creating maps of an object’s lighting or other elements as they appear in the scene, and then applying them back to the object. This option can save considerable rendering time as the lighting of the static objects’ ‘baked’ textures need not be recalculated. More importantly, rendered textures can be exported to other environments such as game engines. Render to Texture allows artists to build more surface details on their meshes and use low-poly objects to represent high-detail scenes, which is great for games, set designs, and film pre-visualisation.

Light also plays an important role in your scenes. 3ds max 5 has Photometric lights which are similar to standard 3ds max lights, but they use ‘energy based computation’, instead of the old

Decision Maker				
I use	Bryce 3D	Maya		3ds max 4
My work involves	Creating basic object modelling	Final integration of animated sequences	Hardcore animation which involves creation of complex objects with the help of a lot of modifiers and then animating them	Hardcore animation which involves creation of complex objects with the help of a lot of modifiers and then animating them
Should I upgrade to 3ds max 5?	Don't upgrade. You don't need the sophisticated features offered by 3ds max 5	Don't upgrade. Maya is far superior to 3ds max in terms of workflow and ease of use	Upgrade. The rearranged menus, the new light features, and inclusion of Reactor and Skin Pose feature tremendously increases productivity	Upgrade. It has several enhanced features. Besides, you can upgrade to version 5 at a mere 22 per cent (approx Rs 32,000 for single user license; Rs 57,000 for Floating License) of its original price if you are a 3ds max 4 user.

